

LIVING WITH PURPOSE

Around the world at this time people are required to stay socially distant from one another in order to help slow the spread of COVID-19. God created us to live in community, so social isolation takes a toll on our psychological health. However, it's critical we take social distancing seriously to prevent healthcare systems from getting overloaded which can ultimately lead to more deaths. As a result, people are spending more time at home and some have more time on their hands than they know what to do with in a creative and positive way.

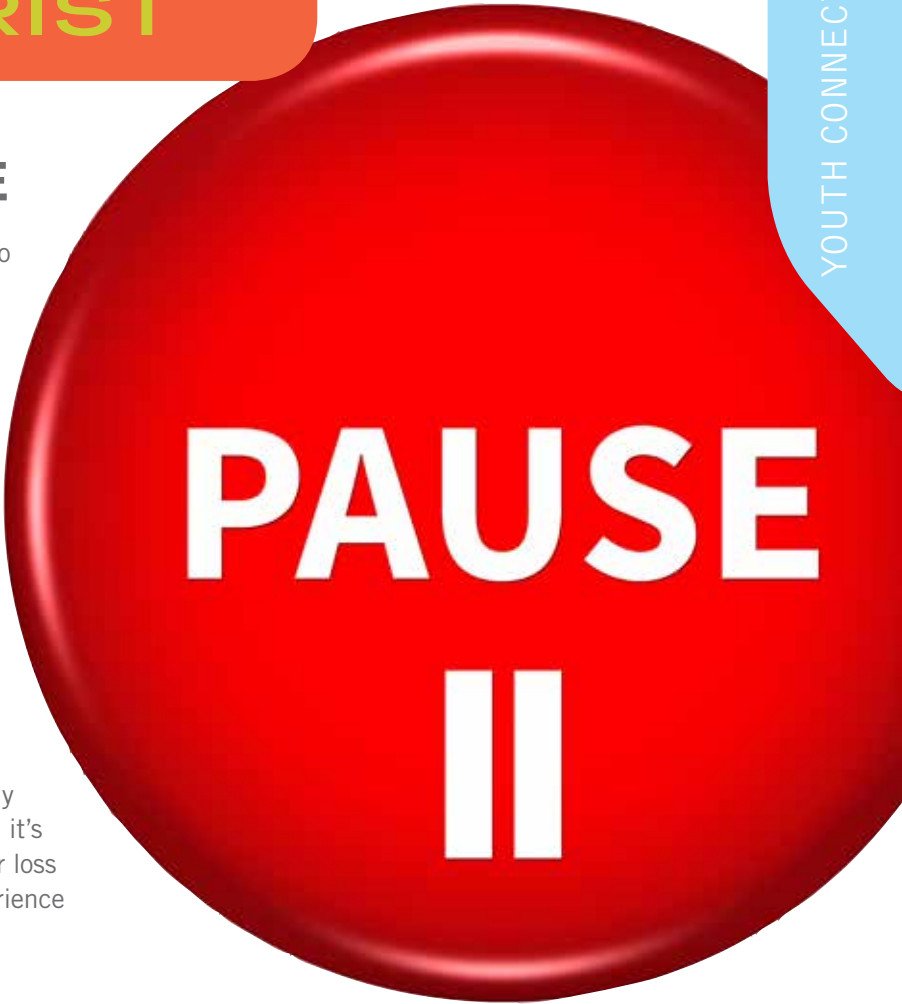
The Great Pause

During this time of quarantine, it's as if someone hit the pause button for most of society. The days are blending together and boredom is hitting some people harder than others. Since we have not collectively experienced anything like this pandemic in our lifetime, it's easy to feel anxious from the unknowns and worries over loss of life, jobs, and normalcy. It's also not unusual to experience boredom.

I'm Bored

Still, boredom isn't necessarily a bad feeling. Many psychologists claim boredom is necessary for our brains to generate creative solutions to problems or serve as an artistic outlet for our anxiety. On the other hand, boredom can cause trouble when we feel tempted to sin or become apathetic. Boredom can lead to incredible ingenuity or creative expressions of our humanity that bring glory to God. In fact, Isaac Newton came up with his greatest discoveries after being sent home from Cambridge University in order to stay safe during the bubonic plague. The year he spent at home was known as his "year of wonders." During this time he discovered important theories about gravity, optics, and calculus.

What if this could be a year of wonders for us? This doesn't mean we have to make a huge discovery or come up with some novel theory. Perhaps during this time we can make room for self-care and self-reflection that will be crucial for our faith development. Perhaps we can learn how to love others better during this time, or even begin a new hobby. Whatever we do during this unique time, it can be an opportunity to explore the good things God has planned for us.



PAUSE

TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

Be sure to mention that not everyone is experiencing boredom during this time. Some families are busier than ever. Every household is different. Life can be stressful while parents and teens are trying to work, conduct school, and keep up with other new responsibilities as a result of the pandemic and all the changes. It's important not to make assumptions about others' feelings. Remind teens who feel stressed and busy they don't have to take on additional tasks, but to remember to bring glory to God in whatever they do.

TEACHER BIBLE PREP



HOLY LIVING

Question of the Day: What's the funniest thing online you have seen someone doing out of boredom?

Purpose: To motivate teens to live enthusiastically with purpose instead of apathy.

Cultural Connection: Boredom from Social Isolation

Topic: Purposeful Living

WHAT DAY IS IT?

Ecclesiastes 8:15

So I commend enjoyment because there's nothing better for people to do under the sun but to eat, drink, and be glad. This is what will accompany them in their hard work, during the lifetime that God gives under the sun. —Ecclesiastes 8:15

Commentary:

It's easy to become cynical and apathetic about life during this time when all our days are blending together. The Book of Ecclesiastes is a cynical poetic expression of how life can feel meaningless and expresses this idea more than twenty times. The author wants us to see that life viewed from a human perspective seems to be nothing but unending cycles of meaningless events. It's a poetic message about the reality of how life feels apart from God. The critic reminds us that even when life feels meaningless, we can still find joy in the simple pleasures of life that God offers us. Jesus teaches true meaning in life is found in our relationship with God. Our purpose is to love God and love others with all our hearts, and we will live an abundant life.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What motivates you to get out of bed each day?
- ▶ What brings you true joy and purpose?
- ▶ How does your relationship with Christ give meaning to your life?

STAY ANCHORED IN JESUS

Colossians 3:1-17

Whatever you do, whether in speech or action, do it all in the name of the Lord Jesus and give thanks to God the Father through him. —Colossians 3:17

**What
Day
Is
It?**

Commentary:

When we are bored, we tend to indulge in activities that offer easy distraction from our current suffering. Everyone needs a distraction once and a while, but sometimes boredom can lead to self-indulgence or unhealthy habits. Paul reminds us in the Book of Colossians that we are meant to live in a way that brings glory to God. Paul writes the letter to teach those in the city of Colossae that their purpose is in Christ. He goes to great lengths in chapter three to express what it looks like to live a purposeful life anchored in God's goodness and love. Notice Paul says nothing about our purpose having to do with success, career, money, fame, status, or power. Instead, we are invited to live a life rich with meaning by reflecting the love of Jesus in everything we do.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ How can boredom be used to bring glory to God?
- ▶ What sin or unhealthy habits attract you when you feel bored?
- ▶ What can you do each day to give your life more purpose and meaning?

SPIRITUAL FITNESS

1 Timothy 4:7-10

While physical training has some value, training in holy living is useful for everything. It has promise for this life now and the life to come. —1 Timothy 4:8

Commentary:

Paul put Timothy, a young elder, in charge of helping to spiritually grow the Ephesian church. Paul writes letters to mentor Timothy as he disciples the believers. In his letter

TEACHER BIBLE PREP



to Timothy, Paul affirms the importance of spiritual growth being even more important than physical training for our earthly bodies. We know exercise is an essential part of life. Spiritual growth is even more crucial for lives. It's important to find ways to grow spiritually during this pandemic. While we are figuring out how to reschedule our lives and form new habits, we must include ways we can grow in our faith.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ How has not being able to physically go to church helped or hindered your spiritual growth?
- ▶ What old habits have you maintained to help grow in your faith?
- ▶ What new habits could you nurture in order to grow in your faith?

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DEVOTION: BRINGING GLORY TO GOD

Being stuck in jail sounds stressful, terrifying, and even boring. The apostle Paul references his time spent in jail several times throughout our Scripture. However, while stuck in jail, he used his time to disciple others and bring glory to God. Reflect on the following Scripture:

Brothers and sisters, I want you to know that the things that have happened to me have actually advanced the gospel. The whole Praetorian Guard and everyone else knows that I'm in prison for Christ. Most of the brothers and sisters have had more confidence through the Lord to speak the word boldly and bravely because of my jail time. — Philippians 1:12-14

While in jail, Paul wrote important letters that helped spread the gospel of Jesus. He wrote the books of Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon while in captivity. Activists like Martin Luther King, Jr. and Nelson Mandela also spent time in jail and wrote letters that played major roles while inspiring people to fight injustice and ignite peaceful protests against their oppressors.

While most of us are far from experiencing the hardship of jail, many of us are limited more than we prefer. Perhaps someday we will look back on this time and realize the boredom and the imposed limits were actually



Paul affirms the importance of spiritual growth being even more important than physical training for our earthly bodies.

a gift. Maybe we will look back on this dark and isolated time in our lives and realize that God was actually up to something remarkable.

NEXT WEEK:

What day is it, anyway? Are you sure? The extended quarantine is messing with everyone's sense of time. Next week in LinC we'll talk about how to keep our head straight.

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GIVE GOD THE GLORY

Getting Ready: Prior to the video call, ask students to collect their Bibles, Youth Page 6, and pens or pencils.

Before the Session:

- Email Youth Page 6 to your students.
- Collect three objects from around your house that bring you joy. Be sure these items are simple, such as a favorite food or beverage, a game, a picture, a pet, a song, a book, a trinket, a memento, a photo, or an instrument. Do not choose your phone or computer or similar items. The point is to focus on simple pleasures.

OPEN

Who Would You Rather . . . ? (8–10 minutes)

Ask and talk about the following questions:

- ▶ Who has been feeling bored lately?
- ▶ Who feels stressed or busier than normal?

Using the last paragraph on Page 1, describe how boredom can lead us toward either bad habits or creative ingenuity. Say: “Boredom can also be an opportunity for seeking new ways to have fun with friends and family. Let’s have a little fun right now by playing the game “Who Would You Rather . . . ?”

Ask, “Would you rather quarantine with . . .”

- Captain Marvel or Wonder Woman?
- Captain America or Iron Man?
- Darth Vader or Kylo Ren?
- BB8 or C3PO?
- Billie Eilish or Lizzo?
- Ariana Grande or Jonas Brothers?
- Thanos or Hela (Thor’s Sister)?
- Batman or Spiderman?
- Baby Yoda or Baby Groot?

- Obama or Elon Musk?
- Harry Potter or Percy Jackson?

Ask, “If you could socially isolate with one famous person or fictional character, who do you think would keep you from getting bored?”

EXPLORE

Talk Topic 1: When Every Day Feels Meaningless (10–15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Say: “During these days of social isolation, it’s easy to feel like everyday is the same or even that everyday feels meaningless. The Book of Ecclesiastes has wisdom to share with us about feeling like everything is meaningless.” Use the commentary in Teacher Bible Prep to give a quick summary of the Book of Ecclesiastes.

Now, invite a teen to read aloud Ecclesiastes 8:15. Then ask and discuss: “According to this verse, what can we do to find joy when life feels meaningless—perhaps especially when we feel bored?”

Show the three objects you found around your house that bring you joy. Then ask teens to go and find three items around their houses that bring them joy. Explain the objects should be simple, such as a favorite food or beverage, a game, a picture, a pet, a song, a book, a trinket, a memento, a photo, or an instrument. Discourage them from choosing their phones or computers as their objects. When all the teens return, allow them to share their objects.

Say: “When we feel bored, it can be an opportunity to learn to find joy in the simple pleasures God provides and to remind ourselves that God wants good things for us. As we enjoy these simple pleasures, let’s remember to give thanks to God. Our thanksgiving brings God glory.”

High School Option

Ask: “By a show of hands, how many of you have felt like life is meaningless at some point during this time of social isolation?” Then say: “You are not alone. In fact, there’s a book in the Bible that talks about how every day is meaningless. Let’s check it out.”

Show teens the following video about the Book of Ecclesiastes at: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VeUiuSK81-0>.

After watching the video, ask and talk about:

- ▶ What images or words of wisdom stuck out to you during this video?
- ▶ What does the Scripture tell us to do in order to enjoy our life even when everything feels meaningless? (Read aloud Ecclesiastes 8:15 if necessary.)



GIVE GOD THE GLORY



- ▶ What simple pleasures are you noticing and enjoying while spending more time at home?
- ▶ How can enjoying simple pleasures bring glory to God?

Talk Topic 2: Let Boredom Lead to Wonders (10–15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Explain that teens will collectively compose a story. As leader, begin the story by saying aloud one sentence. For example, say: “One day I was sitting at home feeling bored out of my mind when I heard a knock on the door. I went to open the door and saw” Then call on someone to go next and add to the story with another sentence or two. That person will then call on someone else to add a sentence or two until each person has had a turn to add to the story. Encourage teens to dig into their fun and creative side. After a few minutes, feel free to end the story yourself.

Using information on Page 1, explain to teens how boredom can lead to fun and creative opportunities. Mention the example of how boredom during quarantine inspired Isaac Newton to make new discoveries. Invite teens to take a five minutes of quiet time to read Colossians 3:17 silently. Then use the commentary in Teacher Bible Prep to explain the context, before using the questions provided there to lead a discussion.

High School Option

Invite teens to read Colossians 3:1-17 on their own for about five minutes. Use the commentary in Teacher Bible Prep to explain the context of the passage before using the questions provided to lead discussion. Ask teens to describe on Youth Page 6 what it looks like for them to give God the glory in everything they do.

After a few minutes, ask for a volunteer to read aloud what he or she wrote. Then remind teens that boredom can lead to unhealthy habits, or it can lead us toward something creative and beautiful. Using the information on Page 1, talk about how boredom during quarantine played a role in many of Isaac Newton’s key discoveries.

Again, on Youth Page 6, invite teens to list topics about which they want to learn or discover new information. Remind the youth they don’t have to come up with huge discoveries like Isaac Newton, but that now is a great time to try new activities or learn about new things since they have extra time on their hands.

BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Watch this one-minute video about why boredom is good at: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K710qprgtjo>. Then ask and talk about the following:

- ▶ Why do you think boredom makes people so uncomfortable?
- ▶ How often do you turn to your phone or technological devices when you are bored?

- ▶ How can boredom actually be good for you?
- ▶ How have you seen God at work in your life, or in others’ lives, while experiencing boredom?

Talk Topic 3: Grow Your Soul (10–15 minutes)

Combined Middle School and High School Option

Call on a few teens to quickly describe their typical daily schedule during this pandemic.

Say: “The required social distancing and isolation affects different families in different ways. Some people are busier than others due to workload and increased hours or different school requirements. Others have more free time than they can fill.”

On Youth Page 6, circle a number on the scale that represents how lazy or busy you have felt this week (1 being super lazy and 10 being so busy you want to explode). Call on teens who would like to share their answers.

Say: “As Christians, we must be careful not to fall into the extremes of being too lazy or too busy. Instead we should strive for a balance of hard work and sabbath. Our goal should always be holy living, involving discipline and self-care.”

Invite a teen to read aloud 1 Timothy 4:7-10, then ask and talk about the following:

- ▶ Why is training for holy living even more important than physical training?
- ▶ How have you been personally trying to grow in your faith during this pandemic?
- ▶ What are some new habits you would like to try to grow spiritually?

Ask teens to think of and commit to one thing they will try and do this week to help them grow in their faith.

TAKE AWAY

Boredom may feel uncomfortable, but it’s important we bring our boredom to Christ. Let’s ask Jesus to use our boredom as an opportunity to bring glory to God in all that we do.

**Our goal should always be holy living,
involving discipline and self-care.**

WORKING IT OUT

FROM BOREDOM TO WONDER . . .

Make a list of new activities or hobbies you want to try or discover. Here are some examples:

- 🌀 Cooking or baking
- 🌀 Reading a book you normally wouldn't choose
- 🌀 Write a song or a poem
- 🌀 Journaling
- 🌀 Learn to play the harmonica
- 🌀 Meditating
- 🌀 Learn to sew
- 🌀 Make a funny video
- 🌀 Invent or build something

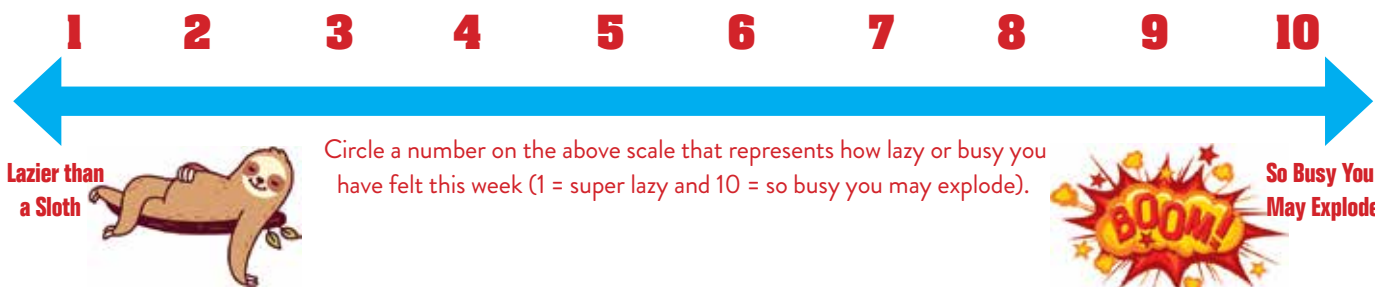
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What does it look like to give God the glory in everything you do?

In the Bible: Readings for the Week

MONDAY: Read James 4:14.

Life is short. Make the most of it.

TUESDAY: Read Romans 5:3-5.

How do hardships give us meaning and purpose?

WEDNESDAY: Read 1 Corinthians 10:31.

In what areas of your life do you need to give more glory to God.

THURSDAY: Read John 10:10.

How does Jesus fulfill our lives?

FRIDAY: Read Proverbs 19:15.

What can you do to prevent laziness?

SATURDAY: Read Matthew 28:18-20.

What command purpose did Jesus leave us with before he ascended to heaven?

Inherit the Mirth



WHAT'S TRENDING?

What did you do today even though you didn't have to? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #onpurpose on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministypartners